

The Naval War

The US Navy launched airstrikes, engaged in search-and-destroy operations, and transported aircraft and artillery. It was the first service to go into formal combat operations in 1965 and it was the last one to leave Vietnam a decade later.

◀◀ BEFORE

The US Navy had been a source of support for the South Vietnamese government since the 1950s.

ADVISORY ROLE

In the 1950s, the US Navy provided guidance to South Vietnam's Navy and advised the government on infrastructure projects and civic action programs. These **advisory and nation-building missions** continued throughout the war.

FIRST COMBAT ACTION

The US Navy's airstrikes against North Vietnam after the **Tonkin Gulf incident** in 1964 marked the United States' first overt combat operations of the war.

Although the US Navy did not have to contend with serious threats from North Vietnamese naval forces on the high seas, the Seventh Fleet provided critical support to the war effort in a broad range of capacities. At Yankee Station, a point off the central coast of South Vietnam, multiple aircraft carriers launched airstrikes against North Vietnam and the Ho Chi Minh Trail as part of operations Flaming Dart, Rolling Thunder, and Linebacker, among others. Warships at Yankee Station also shelled the coast of North Vietnam and provided artillery support to American units operating in South Vietnam. At Dixie Station, much farther south, a single-carrier group provided close air support for US troops engaged in combat operations. Other Navy missions included advising the Republic of Vietnam Navy, transporting troops to Vietnam, building US bases, constructing and maintaining South Vietnamese port facilities, providing medical support in shipboard surgical hospitals, and coastal defense.